

PRACTICE BETTER!

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #45

The biggest initial consideration to make as we think about practicing jazz and improvisation is in how we divide our time between Playing and Practicing. This is huge, and can't be overstated. Those are two totally different things, and most of us tend to ignore one side of the equation, or are far more comfortable with the other (and hence overweighted in that direction).

40% of your practice time should be PLAYING music

Let's define this as "in time, as if someone were listening to you." This is literally playing songs, as if you were performing. With focus and intention. If you are soloing, your solo shouldn't "just stop" because you get tired. Your solos should have a beginning, a middle and an end, like your heroes do on stage. If the phone rings, you don't answer it. You are on stage. Just PLAY SONGS (ie. real composed music), for 40% of your practice time. Playing written melodies, playing jazz tunes, playing improvised solos.

- 1) Some of this 40% practice time should be IN TIME and ACCOMPANIED. Of course, playing with a "real band" is the best. Join a jazz small group class, set up a jam session, join a band. Otherwise, backing tracks, iRealPro, Aebersolds, or whatever you like and have access to is perfect.
- 2) Some of this practice time should be IN TIME and UNACCOMPANIED. Here we are developing your sense of time, groove and feel, in addition to everything from #1 above.
- 3) Some of this should be OUT OF TIME and UNACCOMPANIED. Here we are further developing your sense of melody and harmony, and your ability to imply harmony with pure melody. We are thinking about thoughtful phrasing and embellishment.

PRACTICE BETTER (CON'T)

60% of your practice time should be PRACTICING music

This is the background work. In general, this shouldn't sound very good. If you are sounding too good as you are PRACTICING, you aren't doing it right! Practice is about pushing the boundaries of what you are currently able to do.

An Incomplete List Of Topics For This 60% Of Your Practice Time -

SOUND - Depending on the instrument, this could be practice with long tones, harmonics, stick control, relaxation, hand position, breathing, electronics and EQ, voicing and much more. Most important is to *have a goal of what or who you want to sound like*.

TECHNIQUE (both Mental Technique and Mechanical/Finger Technique). Scales, written etudes, challenging songs, flexibility exercises, extending your range, working with root motions, metronome work, etc.

VOCABULARY - Licks, melodic devices, chord voicings, transcriptions, etc. Anywhere you can find a small nugget that you like. Very important is to work these ideas into other keys and root motions (this goes back to “mental technique,” above).

EARS - Listening to jazz (*focused* listening, not “doing the dishes” listening). Singing the root motions of jazz songs as an ear training exercise. Transcribing, even if it's just a measure or two. Listening to live jazz.